

Whitepaper: Synthetic Reality and the Architecture of Perpetual Crisis

Date: June 13, 2026 **Subject:** Strategic Employment of Existential Disruption as a Tool for Authoritarian Control

1. Executive Summary

This paper examines the theoretical and strategic utility of "existential disruption"—the systematic manufacture of high-stakes, unverifiable crises (such as the simulated duplication of individuals or the environment)—as a mechanism for regime consolidation. By eroding the shared epistemic framework (the "shared reality") of a population, authoritarian regimes can induce a permanent state of hyper-vigilance, reduce the capacity for critical dissent, and enforce total dependence on the state for security.

2. The Theoretical Framework: "Vibocracy" and Epistemic Erosion

The collapse of a shared reality is not merely a byproduct of chaos but can be a deliberate governance strategy. In environments characterized by "vibocracy," public life and decision-making are shaped not by evidence or deliberative reasoning, but by affective resonance and performative legitimacy (Fendt, 2026).

When a regime introduces an existential, unverifiable threat, it triggers a "sense-making" process within the populace. According to the Existential Threat Model, when individuals perceive an impending, uncontrollable threat, they are cognitively predisposed to detect patterns and assign agency—often shifting toward conspiracy-oriented thinking (Mao, 2026). By controlling the narrative of this threat, the regime positions itself as the sole entity capable of interpreting—and thus mitigating—the danger.

3. Strategic Objectives of Existential Disruption

Authoritarian regimes may employ such tactics to achieve three primary objectives:

A. The "War-Footing" as a Permanent State

Persistent military mobilization and the threat of war fundamentally erode the culture of democratic deliberation (Crawford, 2026). By framing existence itself as under attack, the regime justifies:

- **Suspension of Accountability:** Normal institutional checks and balances are discarded as "unaffordable luxuries" in an existential crisis.
- **Resource Extraction:** The population becomes more willing to authorize extreme tax, labor, and surveillance measures under the guise of "defensive" necessity.

B. Cognitive Exhaustion and Epistemic Dependency

Gaslighting, when elevated to a leadership style, functions by systematically inverting shared norms and besmirching the validity of objective facts (Risse, 2026). By injecting "synthetic realities" (e.g., the potential for duplication), the state creates:

- **Epistemic Dependency:** If citizens cannot trust their own senses or the reliability of their peers, they are forced to defer to the state's "official" interpretation of reality.
- **Social Fragmentation:** By making every citizen a potential "duplicate" or threat, the regime dismantles horizontal trust (between citizens), forcing all trust to be directed vertically (toward the state).

C. Reduction of Bottom-Up Resistance

Research indicates that indoctrination and the signaling of regime strength are associated with lower probabilities of anti-system mobilization (Tetteh & Edgell, 2024). A population preoccupied with an existential, invisible, and complex threat has significantly less "cognitive bandwidth" to organize for democratic reform.

4. Risks and Societal Outcomes

While these strategies may provide short-term stability, they carry severe systemic risks:

- **Regime Fragility:** Constant reliance on fear-based mobilization can be counterproductive. As noted in the "Strategy of Tension," such methods may eventually lead to a volatile backlash once the population realizes the nature of the deception or becomes desensitized to the alarmist rhetoric.
- **Security Dilemma:** A population living in perpetual fear is prone to miscalculation. When the state forces an "Us vs. Them" mentality through fabricated threats, the risk of unnecessary, catastrophic kinetic conflict increases.
- **Institutional Decay:** The long-term erosion of evidence-based policy makes the state incapable of addressing *genuine* crises (e.g., pandemics, economic collapse), as the machinery of government has been hollowed out to serve the "performative" crisis instead.

5. Conclusion

The employment of simulated existential threats represents the next evolution in authoritarian control: the transition from controlling what a population *does* to controlling what a population *perceives as real*. By replacing the industrial commons with an "epistemic commons" managed by the regime, the state creates an environment where dissent is not only prohibited but becomes cognitively inconceivable.

References

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